‘Machine Dreams: Biophilia’ by Anadol Studios 2025, created for last year’s Biennale, is one of many similar displays spread around museums and big-tech and finance office buildings.

The description for the work on Anadol’s website scores 100% on GPTZero, an online neural network generated text detector.

Apparently, these works ‘bring nature to life’ and offers an encounter with a ‘mind’ that we are training to “learn and remember what we can only dream of”.

“AI” HAS NOT ARRIVED.
NEURAL NETWORKS ARE A TECHNOLOGY.
MADE, DESIGNED AND USED BY HUMANS.
THE STORIES WE CONSTRUCT ABOUT IT MATTER.

Techno-futurist rhetoric constructs “AI” as an epistemically superior, autonomous mind, contrasting it against limited, emotional human subjectivity to legitimise its current uses.

“[AI] is the present, it’s already here, in Britain”, the only options are “grasp [AI] and run with it” or be left behind.

Keir Starmer
UK PM, 2025

Dario Amodei
Antropic CEO

All watched over by machines of loving grace

“The brain needs to be replaced by AI, emotions, intuitions need to be replaced by big data and predictive analytics,[...] This is magic. [...] Our AI[...] measure candidates [...] who they really are, who they will be”

"[AI is] disruptive force in history [...] something that is smarter than the smartest human [...]the AI will be able to do everything. So I don't know if that makes people comfortable or uncomfortable. It's [laughter]… you know, that's why I say if you wish for a magic genie that gives you any wishes you want and there's no limit"

Elon Musk
Palantir advisor

“Becoming Technological Supermen
We believe that advancing technology is one of the most virtuous things that we can do. [...] Technology must be a violent assault on the forces of the unknown, to force them to bow before man.”

Q: do you think humnaity should survive?
“Uh…”
“Well, I don’t know. I would — I would”
“There’s so many questions”

Carl Eschenbach
Workday CEO, 2023

Peter Thiel
CEO of Palantir, IDF civilian target chooser

Marc Andreessen
Investor in Facebook and many other neural network and data-based companies

This rhetoric exploits fears of obsolescence and inaccess to a nature of things hidden in a ‘world’ of data, framing “AI” as a mystical superior being. Often contrasting the detractor or the human as backward, irrational, weak, and biased.

Neural networks originate in the same lines of thinking that conceives of workers as processing units in a circuit. Optimised NN's supposed superior objectivity relies on an inflationary view of what they are, and the 'world' of data they supposedly inhabit. This inflationary view obscures the human hand in, and material costs of, their making.

ART SHOULD WORK TO UNDERMINE THE VENEER OF LIGHTNESS AND EPISTEMIC POWER PERVASIVE IN THE SALES-RHETORIC

Anadol’s work participates in the same construction

Like the techno-futurist construction of AI, in *arrival* the aliens appear without warning, a benevolent, superhuman power bringing technology: irrevocably changing humanity.
Anadol’s presentation uses the same visual language. The human figure is dwarfed by an overwhelming, literally *mist*-erious entity from another world. In Anadol’s work, the speed and quantity of data presented, the overwhelming size, and incomprehensibility is constructive.

To describe the process of optimising a neural network in the creation of artwork as a collaboration is like describing the process of making soup as collaboration with the pot and hob. Yes, unexpected and interesting things might happen when you heat it up, but how much you stir, what you put in and when, and how it cooks for still ultimately determines the outcome. Anadol Studios’ work is the heavily curated output of a software system that was made.